

Caddy Liu

Professor Marcel Daniels

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Teaching effectiveness for disadvantaged groups in educational inequities

In my first DJ [10/14], I said that the perception "unlike preschoolers and juniors, fifth graders should be able to manage themselves, at least not as much as most of them are slapdash or inattentive." was noticed and commented on by Professor Marcel, who asked "Where does this one come from - your memory as a fifth grader? Observations? Something else?" I reflected on this and realized it was based on my upbringing and understanding of my surroundings. Conclusions are drawn from my surroundings. In the same DJ [10/14], I mentioned, "This is my first misjudgment: their English level is not a solid foundation." Professor Marcel commented, "especially in this teaching context, it should be to assess the student's levels so you can be better prepared moving forward." He used to "assess" instead of "surmise." I reflected again and realized that I had made the same mistake. My repeated and unsupported assumptions about my students' backgrounds and levels in the first lesson were narrow-minded.

So, I consulted the teacher at Stepping Stones after class where my students came

from. She talked about them being from Zunyi, Guizhou Province. I taught the class online. Based on Googling the school and the classroom environment in the camera, I recognized that they were elementary school students from a rural area and that the local economy was backward. I think this affects their level of education because the economy limits access to quality educational resources. Therefore, education is unequal for them. As a disadvantaged group in this phenomenon, this coincides with their classroom performance. The other students in my class teach English classes to migrant children from Shanghai, and I think they are also disadvantaged.

Next, I need to think about how to teach this group of students.

Although we come from different educations and upbringings, children are similar. So, I borrowed the methods that my teachers have been using. First, I tried to create a system of rewards and punishments to give different feedback and rewards for different student performances. The result of the application was in my DJ [10/27]: "the students who scored the highest marks in the previous lesson were even more active in this lesson." The children were also motivated by rewards and punishments, which boosted their self-confidence. This finding also resonates with Sophia's DJ [11/29], saying "When I praise a student for their participation and say compliments such as 'amazing job,' 'great job,' or 'you are correct,' the student will be more motivated to participate the next time because they feel their contributions are valued."

The next step is to adapt the content and format of the instruction. In my DJ [11/9], " 'bluish-greenish' which I didn't think was very common, so I simplified it to green and blue and added the words that weren't in the textbook, such as 'brown, 'gray', etc." In

addition to this, I applied translanguaging. In CBI " this does not necessarily mean that L1 is used directly, nor does it mean that students do not need to be exposed to L2", on the contrary, "CBI has the advantage of keeping learners intrinsically motivated and interested, among other things" (Wang, 97). This is because students can understand the content through the language, they are familiar with and are free to express themselves. So, I tried, according to my forum post [11/12], "When I taught the word 'nose' in the fourth lesson, I first introduced the word by following the slides and the pictures. Then, when guiding students to read aloud and memorize the word, I pointed to my nose and said 'nose' and interacted with them: '让我看看谁还没有指他的 nose' (Let me see who hasn't pointed to their nose yet) ."

I have had self-doubt and guilt about these because I am unsure if simplifying the content and not using all-English instruction deprives my students of an already scarce, quality educational resource. However, in Ari Harris' forum post [10/31] "they intend to provide disadvantaged communities with resources that are available to others, but not common within their communities. I feel that the mission of Stepping Stones was not found with the intention of teaching English so these kids can be seen as more elite members of society." This helps me explain the balance.

However, I still wanted to help my students more. During Halloween week, I tweaked the course syllabus, recording in my DJ [10/27] that "So, the theme of my third lesson was 'Bad Bat,' in which I led the students to understand the cultural background and celebration of Halloween." Because behind language is culture. According to Pennycook, "but rather with the worldliness of English, its relationship to class,

education and culture, the materiality of its imposition on these students at secondary school" (12) . I want to teach my students not only the language of English but more about the culture behind English. I think it will also bring them more interest and expand their horizons. This lesson was a success. So, as Thanksgiving was approaching, in my seventh lesson, I spent ten minutes before the end of the class to add the culture and customs of Thanksgiving and left a homework assignment: to say to a person that today is Thanksgiving and thank you.

Later, my students have had a class canceled due to equipment failure. I was temporarily assigned to teach students from Henan Province at the same grade level. Henan is a strong education province, and in the course of teaching, I once again realized the disparity in outcomes due to inequity in education. I was amazed at how the students in Henan Province could fully understand and interact with me when I used full English for the same grade level. Meanwhile, in the following week's lesson, I gave the same lesson to my students. I did not expect them to perform as well as the students in Henan, which was another stereotypical influence on me. However, the truth is that my students completed the lesson very smoothly and successfully with the reward and punishment system and translanguaging teaching methods that were laid out before. They are in an excellent position to learn English, and I am pleased that I have developed such a positive rapport with my students.

Just when I was expecting to be able to lead them to learn more in subsequent teaching, as I recorded in the last DJ [12/2], "last week I was first told that the students would be taking their monthly exams and classes would be canceled for the day. Then

I received a letter from a teacher at Stepping Stones saying that the principal of the school contacted me on Tuesday because they are trying to improve the quality of education in the county (most notably because the school's students are at the bottom of the list in language arts and math), and the school's teachers are afraid that they will be criticized by name, so they have to stop teaching English this semester, and then teachers at the school will have to focus on language arts and math as their next two subjects. ” It is a pity, not only because I cannot be with my students for the rest of the semester, but also because, subject to the views and policies of educators, my students are once again deprived of a rare and hard-won resource.

At this stage, I can only wish my students well. I want educational resources to be more equitable so that they will have a more exciting future! It has been a rich, memorable and valuable teaching journey. I recorded the ending and Sophia said in the final response [12/4], “As you navigate these challenges and continue to contribute to education, please know that your dedication and positive impact are not going unnoticed. I believe that students will remember that they had an English teacher named Caddy.” This is very touching and I want to express my gratitude: Thank you, my teaching partner, Sophia. Thank you, DSS. Thank you, Prof. Marcel. Thank you, my classmates. Thank you, Stepping Stones. Thank you, my students.

works cited

- Wang, Ping. "A case study of the translanguaging phenomenon in CBI classes in a Chinese University context." *International Journal of Applied Linguistics*, vol. 31, no. 1, 2020, pp. 95–108, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ijal.12324>.
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